Matthew McKay, Ph.D.

How I work (LIB-41)

Purpose: one page for a hiring manager or new team on how I scope, govern, build and hand off work, so they know what working with me looks like before the first meeting.

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1. Start with the decision

Before I build a report or a course, I ask what decision it's for and who makes it.

Where it shows: every case study opens with the question leaders asked, before any data (case study A).

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2. Define it, then govern it

A metric means the same thing everywhere, or it shouldn't be on a dashboard.

Where it shows: the metric definitions and the disputed-KPI process.

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3. I measure whether it worked, not whether it shipped

The count of completions isn't the outcome. Most of them can't tell you anything until someone decides which ones matter.

Where it shows: the learning measurement plan and case study B.

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4. I write it down

Decisions, definitions, runbooks and handoffs end up in a document someone else can follow, not only in a meeting.

Where it shows: each case study's README and Files section.

5. Hand it off so it runs without me

I'm done when the process works without me in the room.

Where it shows: the report rationalization worksheet and the synthetic data generator, which anyone can rerun.

How I communicate

- **Plainly, with the tradeoff.**
- **Bad news early and directly.**
- **Fewer priorities, finished.**

How I think learning works

Training changes behavior when it's built around a decision someone has to make on the job, practiced close to how they'll actually make it, and reinforced by their manager afterward. That's why I've built meeting-in-a-box kits for managers to use with their teams. If nobody downstream asks "are you doing it differently now?", the course was content, not training. I design backward: first the behavior, then the measure that would show it changed, and only then the smallest thing that gets there. When I can, I take a baseline first, such as a skills assessment before the program starts, so there's something to compare against later.

The practice I'd cut first is the long one-size-fits-all module with a recall quiz at the end. People click through it, pass, and change nothing. I'd rather build role-based practice that puts each group in the situations it actually faces.

Teaching data and business systems at a community college keeps me honest. My students are working adults fitting class around jobs and families. They have no patience for material that doesn't connect to something they'll use, and neither does a workforce. If I can't show why something matters in the first five minutes, I've lost them. I hold workplace learning to the same standard.

Why it's built this way

Most resumes say what someone did. This page says how I'll do it once I'm on your team: how I make decisions, how I'll tell you bad news, and what I'll leave behind when I move on. If that matches how your team works, we should talk. If it doesn't, it saves us both an interview.

Format: web page.

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Personal project. All data is synthetic or public, and the company is fictional. Views are my own and not affiliated with or endorsed by any current or former employer.